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Where to from here? On the borders of academic integrity, academic misconduct, and assessment security after GenAI

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ABSTRACT

This paper evaluates the findings of a series of student focus groups on academic integrity conducted at an Irish university during the 2023–24 academic year. Findings suggest that contemporary Higher Education learners tend strongly to associate the concept of academic integrity with the avoidance of misconduct in summative assessment. While a majority of participants conceived of academic integrity as something requiring episodic attention, a minority thought of it as an intrinsic disposition essential to the entire practice of being a student. This minority of students also considered academic integrity to be a community value requiring participation and cooperation from all members, where those who thought of academic integrity as an event rather than a disposition were more likely to think of it as an individual responsibility. While specific questions on the impact of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) were not put to the focus groups, participants frequently raised it as a source of confusion regarding how academic integrity should now be enacted. We read this in the context of the ongoing academic debates on assessment validity and security and on the ethics of GenAI in education, and find that our participants' lack of clarity around the legitimate uses of GenAI in their practice betray an urgent need for reorientation toward academic integrity as a holistic and intrinsic facet of being a Higher Education student.

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Introduction

At the Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) inflection point, it is critically important to work toward multifaceted new understandings of academic integrity, taking careful account of the perspectives and priorities of both learners and academics. As institutions and policymakers hasten to produce and continuously update policy, procedure, and guidance for educators and learners, we report in the present paper on a persistent uncertainty among learners at an Irish university regarding the meaning and practice of academic integrity, and through analysing learners' thoughts on the concept, we aim to add nuance the literature of academic integrity. Our findings show a mounting confusion about academic integrity among students, who often conflate academic integrity with the avoidance of academic misconduct and, more specifically, of *assessment* misconduct.

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We point, too, to ambiguities in the academic and policy literature about the nature of academic integrity, which often defines the concept, but seldom grounds it in explanation or exemplification of how theory translates to practice. This discursive ambiguity is reproduced to a considerable degree by our focus group participants, who often equate academic integrity with adherence to assessment rules. This appears to restrict the perceived relevance of academic integrity to the sphere of summative assessment of learning, but also to restrain learners from thinking holistically about *learning* with integrity.

Ultimately, participants frame academic integrity less often as a matter of ethics and more often as one of procedure; as a concern for the individual rather than a community; and as an episodic rather than an intrinsic behaviour. This conceptual reduction represents a fundamental challenge as the technological landscape continues to evolve at a pace previously almost inconceivable. Although GenAI's disruption of Higher Education has reinvigorated the debate about the practice(s) of integrity, we are simultaneously experiencing ethical impasse as the sector has yet to metabolise the implications of GenAI's capabilities. As such, what consensus may previously have existed about the ethics of Higher Education has shattered, and the ontological block is yet to be overcome.

Most data on academic misconduct among students currently extant rests upon self-reporting from the learner perspective through the medium of surveys (Benson and Enstroem 2023). A key aim of the present work is to enrich our currently limited knowledge of learners' conceptualisation of educationally (in)appropriate behaviour, therefore, we investigated students' social negotiation of the ideas of academic integrity and misconduct through seven focus group sessions in which a total of 38 students participated during the 2023–24 academic year.

Ten questions were posed to each group, eliciting students' views on valid and relevant assessment instruments, their concepts and experiences of academic integrity (henceforth AI) and academic misconduct (henceforth AM), and their views on new directions for learning, teaching and assessment post-GenAI. Here, we focus on participants' responses to the two questions below, which were posed in the order shown and represented a significant thematic pattern in our data:

- What does the term 'academic integrity' mean, in your view? What could be some examples of students acting with academic integrity?
- What does the term 'academic misconduct' mean to you? What could be some examples of academic misconduct, in your view?

In their responses, a significant majority of participants defaulted to enumerating 'rules' on assessment misconduct avoidance. However, as Dawson et al. (2024) have argued, such lists of rules address cheating management rather than validity, and would need to expand almost ceaselessly to keep pace with the ever-increasing number of ethically unallowable behaviours. Nonetheless, our participants mainly frame AI instrumentally as a set of individual actions to do in summative assessment.

A minority of participants, however, did invoke of the need for a sustained integrity in learning practice throughout the entire student lifecycle. These students described AI as a communitarian matter and a moral–ethical disposition which should be an integral facet of being-a-student, including and extending beyond assessment, and appealing to values such as honesty and responsibility.

That students continue to construct their concept of academic integrity against an obsolescent paradigm betrays a profound conceptual disorientation impacting learners, educators, and policy-makers alike. Our findings would suggest that Corbin et al. (2025a) recent characterisation of GenAI as a 'wicked problem' in assessment applies also to the broader ambit of Higher Education, touching teaching and learning just as it does assessment. It is logical that under conditions of philosophical and practical chaos, learners and scholars would first attend to the most immediate and concrete conundrum – that of assessment validity and security. However, secure assessment alone will not be sufficient to ensure the integrity of Higher Education post-GenAI.

Notes on the literature of academic integrity: problem to concept to practice?

'Academic integrity' became a mainstay of education literature as recently as the 1990s when Donald McCabe and colleagues established it as a standalone field of enquiry (Christensen Hughes and McCabe 2006; Cole and McCabe 1996; McCabe and Klebe Treviño 1993; McCabe, Butterfield, and Klebe Treviño 2006; McCabe, Klebe Treviño, and Butterfield 1999; McCabe, Klebe Treviño, and Butterfield 2001; McCabe, Treviño, and Linda 1997). While much of McCabe's scholarship concerned the impact of the presence or absence of institutional 'honour codes', the studies generally operate on the assumption that integrity results from the control of dishonesty and/or misconduct. However, Dawson (2021) notes that with the proliferation of assessment outsourcing options, primarily digital, available to contemporary learners, a will to adhere to an honour code is not likely to be an effective misconduct deterrent. Corbin et al. (2025a) further note that traditional norms of academic integrity and the possibility of detection previously enabled detection and sanctioning of misconduct, which is now effectively impossible.

The concepts of academic integrity and academic misconduct continue to be invoked almost interchangeably in the literature, however. Davis (2023, 3), for instance, states that academic integrity 'implies a firm adherence to a code of moral values and translates into actions that avoid cheating, plagiarism and contract cheating'. Lancaster et al. (2025) posit the development of institutional policy to deal with academic misconduct as an academic integrity imperative. Similarly, Ellis and Murdoch's (2024) 'educational integrity enforcement pyramid' is intended to curb cheating behaviours – albeit restoratively rather than only punitively – by appropriating principles from regulatory theory developed for industries as diverse as mining and residential care. Luo's (2024, 1) analysis of a sample of 20 university GenAI policies reveals a broad consensus that GenAI potentially erodes the 'originality' of student work, thus transposing the integrity-as-non-plagiarism paradigm to the debate on GenAI ethics in education. Importantly, academic misconduct prevention has also been approached from the theoretical perspective of crime prevention (Birks and Clare 2023; Clare et al. 2022; Hodgkinson et al. 2015), and the facilitation of academic misconduct has been codified in law as an offence across a number of jurisdictions, including New Zealand and Ireland (Draper and Boland 2024).

While thinking of academic integrity as the opposite of academic misconduct may previously have been a serviceable approach, the advent of GenAI and the resultant near-impossibility of accurate or reliable misconduct detection has problematised this binary (Ardito 2024; Perkins et al. 2024). Perkins (2023) makes the case that GenAI contributions to student authorship should not, of themselves, be considered plagiarism, but that a lack of transparent acknowledgement of their use constitutes the new academic misconduct paradigm. A response to this specific change in the assessment landscape is the oft-cited Artificial Intelligence Assessment Scale or AIAS (Furze et al. 2024; Perkins et al. 2024a; Perkins, Roe, and Furze 2024b) which aims to guide academics on defining and communicating to learners the extent to which, and the ways in which they may use GenAI when completing assignments. This simultaneously underscores the impracticability of GenAI bans and detection and reinforces the idea that good assignment practice consists in defining acceptable levels of cognitive outsourcing. Furthermore, there are early indications that requiring students to declare their GenAI use in assessment is broadly ineffective (Gonsalves 2024).

More recently, Corbin, Dawson, and Liu (2025b) have identified the need to move beyond 'declarative' (4) and 'discursive' (5), communication-based guidelines on GenAI usage in assessment such as the AIAS (4), since their effectiveness depends entirely upon students' compliance. Such approaches also risk leaving the 'mechanics' (2) of assessment instruments unaltered, and define the (un)acceptable through linguistic instructions which students may disregard without consequence. 'Structural' (6) changes which delimit the extent to which GenAI use is even possible are offered as a better solution. Importantly, however, the scope of the article is limited to assessment of learning.

Corbin et al. (2025c) call for assessments to be redesigned such that ‘the desired behaviour emerges naturally from the assessment design’ (7) to mitigate the unfeasibility of detection. In short, at least certain elements of the assessment are carried out under conditions where GenAI is inaccessible. They offer the examples of a take-home essay, an online MCQ test, and a lab report, briefly suggesting how these might be altered discursively and structurally, but they justifiably ‘make no claim that the examples [...] represent perfect assessment security’ (7).

The systematic framing of AI as the opposite or avoidance of assessment misconduct is further problematised by policy and educational interventions which invoke integrity in their titles and misconduct in their substance. An example is Ireland’s National Academic Integrity Network’s *National Principles and Lexicon of Common Terms*, which defines and offers many detailed examples of plagiarism, academic dishonesty, contract cheating, and collusion, but defines and does not furnish examples of academic integrity (National Academic Integrity Network 2021). The European Network for Academic Integrity’s (ENAI) glossary of terms defines a similarly wide range of AI- and AM-related terms without situation in examples of practice (Tauginienė 2018), whereas Australia’s Tertiary Education Quality and Standards Agency (TEQSA) enumerates behaviours constitutive of AI, but significantly more that ‘undermine’ it (TEQSA 2022).

The body of literature theorising AI is unexpectedly scant (Mejía and Garcés-Flórez 2025). Definitions and discourses of AI developed to date represent a relatively narrow, bounded concept intended to apply across disciplines, rendering them extremely challenging to operationalise. Even that most conventional measure of academic misconduct, plagiarism, is problematic: the necessarily intertextual nature of thinking and writing makes comprehensive acknowledgement of textual borrowings a complex matter rather than a simple procedure (Howard 2000). GenAI, however, is further enmeshing intertextuality-by-default in a development described as ‘postplagiarism’ (Eaton 2023, 1), suggesting a need to refocus our attentions on ethical knowledge construction. Where today, ‘[u]niversity institutional responses tend to comprise a set of definitions of misconduct, some moral persuasion, and perhaps a little training for incoming students’ (Hodgkinson et al. 2015, 3), the GenAI era demands co-construction by academics and learners of a contemporary ethics of learning.

GenAI also represents a novel integrity ‘shock’, intensifying the debate about professional and educational standards in Higher Education as did contract cheating (Awdry and Newton 2017; Curtis and Clare 2017) and Emergency Remote Assessment (Curtis 2024; Newton and Essex 2024) before it. If it is to be addressed meaningfully, novel AI policy and process should ideally reflect with some degree of clarity not only proscribed but also *prescribed* learner behaviours. For instance, we did not specifically ask participants in our focus groups about GenAI, but they raised their concerns about whether ChatGPT use was a line not to be crossed or a legitimate learning and assessment aid.

Post-GenAI, then, there is no longer a shared ethics of the appropriate. Does GenAI use in learning, teaching and assessment void learning and demand opposition or is it a potentially assistive tool to be thoughtfully integrated? Will it, indeed, revolutionise the effectiveness of education (albeit that this argument assumes that ‘personalisation’ of learning is a virtue rather than a dismantling of the inherently social nature of education)? In the sphere of assessment, such questions are irresolvable and subject only to better or worse mitigation approaches (Corbin et al. 2025a), but we have not yet assessed their status in the broader field of *academic* integrity. To so do will require improved insights on evolving learner views on what is and is not important and what is and is not acceptable in the experience of being a Higher Education student.

Methodology

Our focus groups are a supplement to a survey (see Grimes et al. 2024) intended to allow us to evaluate students’ social negotiation of AI and AM. All students of four of the university’s campuses were invited to participate via an email containing a link to an expression of interest form. Of the 138

students who expressed interest, 38 were ultimately available and willing to participate. While this effectively constituted a convenience sample, all faculties and all degree stages were represented.

We aimed to facilitate participants to co-construct detailed and nuanced understandings of and positions on AI and AM than would be captured either by survey or through individual interviews. Focus group moderators adopted a minimally directive approach, facilitating development of ideas by posing prompts, signalling opportunities for participants to contribute, and elaborating or clarifying prompts where requested (Grønkjær et al. 2011).

Conducted with ethics approval from our university's Human Research Ethics Committee (ref. MTU-HREC-MR-23-024-A), all seven focus group sessions were audio recorded, and verbatim transcripts were produced. The sessions varied in duration from approximately 40 to approximately 90 minutes, depending mostly on the number of participants. All participants were pseudonymised and had given their written informed consent for their transcribed contributions to be included in the dataset for analysis.

Thematic analysis of the data was conducted by the two first authors. This was guided by the research priorities outlined in the introduction and was, as such, a theoretical analysis. Each coder worked independently through data familiarisation with all seven transcripts and through the initial process of open coding of two transcripts using NVivo. Both coders then compared and discussed initial codes, finding a strong degree of similarity in rationales and outcomes. A final set of codes was agreed and was reapplied to the four transcripts already coded and applied to the remaining three, again using NVivo.

With the final coding frame applied, the coders organised codes into descriptive themes. Themes were concept-checked through a visual concept-mapping process to identify overarching patterns in the data, establish connections between them, test their validity, re-test the assignments of codes to each theme, and eliminate any remaining redundancy or overlap in code assignment.

Findings

Our participants' concepts of AI and AM closely mirror the literature's frequent conflation of AI with measures to reduce or eliminate misconduct in summative assessment. This highlights an important problem: how, in the era of instant text-extrusion, can we reframe academic integrity as a sustained feature of *being-a-student* in a university community instead of as a set of now-unenforceable rules to observe episodically when completing summative assessments? We outline below our participants' views on both conceptions: AI as the episodic avoidance of assessment misconduct and AI as a disposition inherent to being a student.

We begin by outlining the more common conception of academic integrity as non-misconduct achieved by adherence to traditional 'lists' of rules. We capture participants' thoughts on the most important components of academic integrity, namely not cheating on or plagiarising assignments, not cheating in exams, referencing, 'owning' one's assessed work, not using ChatGPT (excessively) in assessment completion, not becoming dependent on ChatGPT and, tentatively, using ChatGPT 'ethically'. A final thematic thread involves a wish for more and clearer guidance on the meaning of academic integrity from lecturers and institutions.

Academic integrity as the avoidance of assessment misconduct

Our participants' responses suggest that the conceptual overlap of AI and non-AM is pervasive enough that students have internalised it. It is important to note, however, that this is at least partly a function of to-date incomplete work on theorising academic integrity comprehensively (Mejía and Garcés-Flórez 2025). Under this condition, students cannot realistically be expected to articulate a fine-grained account of an elusive concept. However, achieving an expanded understanding of learner beliefs about academic integrity would logically prefigure the implementation

of capacity-building in terms of artificial intelligence literacy, which has repeatedly been posited as a potential corrective to growing pressures on the maintenance of academic integrity in recent literature (Barrett and Pack 2023; Saunders, Coulby, and Lindsay 2024; UNESCO 2023).

Our respondents made some 41 distinct references to actions that either should not be done or should be done in their efforts toward defining what constitutes AI and AM. This contrasts conspicuously with their 16 distinct references to dispositions and values which comprise integrity, suggesting the framing of AI as the opposite of or a reaction to AM is embedded, perhaps even fossilised.

Being able to assert ownership of one's work, or not cheating on or plagiarising assessments is a definition of AI offered by three students. Work meeting this criterion, they argued, would 'actually represent the level that the student is at, and the effort that they put into the assignment or the exam or whatever it was'. Achieving this level of legitimate ownership of one's assessed work also involved 'actually learning the work yourself', 'studying and not cheating, like, it being your work', and not claiming ownership of work actually produced by another student, a scholar, or, by inference, a chatbot.

A further three participants believe that cheating in an exam or looking at what someone else is writing in an exam setting 'obviously' constitutes academic misconduct. One drew parallels between examination misconduct and misconduct in reporting on experimental work, highlighting the possibility in each scenario to 'copy' work from another student, thereby negating the 'ownership' imperative:

Being dishonest, plagiarism and, like, copying off someone else, cheating in an exam [...] And, there are so many examples of that. I find in Science labs, people take other people's results a lot and because that's not really, like, punished or anything. [...] A lot of people don't end up doing the lab properly and then they just go and copy someone else's. I don't know is that cheating or not, but ... And then, yeah, in exams, like, or if you submit a piece of work and it's not really your own or anything like that.

13 participants understood AI to consist in referencing (seven references) any secondary material integrated into their own assignment text and AM to involve plagiarism (four references) or 'pass[ing] off work that isn't your own ... wilfully deceiving the system.' Where one participant describes referencing as the act of giving credit to the author of any information found *online*, another suggests that using 'reliable sources' was core to producing work with integrity. Plagiarism is perceived to occur when students 'submit a piece of work and it's not really your own,' where its opposite is described by another participant as

being original, [...] having a backbone and what you produce is your own and whatever supporting arguments you get, they're quoted, they're referenced so you're not taking somebody else's work and somebody else's intellectual property as your own.

Integrity, therefore, is constructed as the opposite of *plagiarism*, specifically. This view is shared by two more participants, the first of whom suggests that 'academic integrity would be destroyed if someone plagiarises because you've taken an academic report or document and you've claimed it as your own and therefore the integrity of the document is removed'. The parallel between integrity and anti-plagiarism is slightly problematised, though, by a participant who believes that 'there's a big difference between someone who's either not cited or just cited incorrectly, and someone who's just decided that they're going to take a piece of document'. A final component of the integrity-as-non-plagiarism argument is added by a participant who stresses that 'putting things into your own words and not using Grammarly' ranks alongside referencing as an example of correct academic behaviour.

As noted above, 'ownership' is quite frequently conceptualised by our focus group participants as the opposite of plagiarism and the essence of integrity, particularly in assessment, with nine students invoking this. Additionally, one student suggested that AI also required academic and disciplinary competence, and believes that to complete an assignment with AI requires 'understanding the question that's been given and just having knowledge and putting the correct information on the sheet, I

suppose, and then the examples'. This participant has identified *preconditions* to the plagiarism avoidance discussed by other participants by highlighting the need for conceptual clarity and argumentation through logical progression of ideas.

Conversely, submitting patchwritten work or plagiarised material was thought by five participants to be tantamount to AM. This was discussed both holistically, as a breach of the norms of academic life ('going against the grain of what you're taught about in college ... cheating and submitting someone else's work that isn't your own and that you just weren't putting any effort into what you were given, like your assignment or your exams') and technically, as an exercise in keeping one's 'plagiarism percentage' below a specified maximum.

Turning to the specific challenges of GenAI, one participant specifically names avoidance of ChatGPT as core to integrity, indicating at least some belief that eschewing GenAI assistance is as important as cheating avoidance and honest effort.

Like if you're a really integral student [*sic.*], I imagine that's a student that studies hard, helps people out, engages with the lecturers, engages in class discussion, doesn't, like, cheat in anything, *doesn't use ChatGPT*, and just generally puts their best foot forward and is an honest, good student. [emphasis ours]

ChatGPT's use to complete assessments was equated with misconduct. Three participants expressed the view that doing this was contrary to correct academic conduct. More particularly, they emphasised that ChatGPT compromises the ownership requirement. Four believed that using ChatGPT in the assignment process was a clear example of academic misconduct. Consequences accruing from using ChatGPT and being 'caught' were deemed to be the student's own 'fault' since 'they know that you shouldn't be using it'.

Similarly, another participant – noting that lecturers had suggested that they know when text is produced by ChatGPT and that the submission of such text would result in no marks being awarded – described the choice to have GenAI produce academic work amounted to 'setting yourself up to fail'. The same student expressed tacit support for using GenAI as an aid to earlier assignment stages such as idea generation, but was insistent that the risk of failing an assignment was motivation enough to ensure that all work submitted satisfied the 'ownership' criterion.

Another student, however, suggested that ChatGPT use was commonly masked by light editing of the chatbot's text output. Responding to our prompt on AM, they offered the example of '... using ChatGPT. Just typing in the question into that and then just changing the odd few words around, which I know is really common. And then, like, just getting fake references as well'.

While use of GenAI in the assignment process was generally equated with misconduct, a degree of nuance regarding its possible legitimate use in assessment was also observed. Specifically, two participants perceived a boundary between productive use of GenAI and *dependence* on it, which was perceived as a pathway not only to AM, but also to learning loss.

I don't know if it's technically a bad thing. I think that being over-dependent and over-reliant on it is a bad thing. It's like everything is evolving so ... I just think that being over-dependent is the problem and not the actual software.

However, uncertainty about legitimate and unethical GenAI usage was obvious, further underscoring the need for greater clarity on AI after GenAI's integration into educational and industrial settings, as highlighted by the above contribution. A second participant says of the the links between the two environments:

Like, if you get into the habit of using and depending on it, you're also kind of stunting your own learning and, like, it prevents you from kind of progressing and, like, it's the whole point of college, like, to be challenging yourself, you know? And so then when you're going into the real world, you might be a bit like, 'what do I do?' You need to kind of fend for yourself.

Interestingly, this participant – contrary to the literature's more common urge to integrate GenAI into learning, teaching and assessment (O'Dea 2024; Pratschke 2024; Smeaton 2025) to prepare

learners for an artificial intelligence-infused workplace (Chan and Hu 2023; Chan and Tsi 2024; Chiu 2024) – surmises that over-reliance on GenAI could limit not only educational attainment but also readiness to enter the workplace confidently. Similar trepidations about over-reliance were found in a survey of Hong Kong-based Higher Education learners by Chan and Hu (2023). Their concerns spanned accuracy of information generated, the ethics of GenAI use, the potential stunting of intellectual and personal development, the possible obsolescence of the professional roles for which they are preparing, justice and equality implications, and the current policy vacuum regarding acceptable use of GenAI within institutional – especially university – contexts.

Although eight participants in our focus groups mentioned ChatGPT usage as an example of misconduct, a further three offered nuanced evaluations of potentially *ethical* GenAI use. Specifically, they believed that it is legitimate and ethical to use ChatGPT as an aid in the early stages of assignment preparation, particularly as a way of ‘generating ideas’ and helping learners to ‘understand the key words’ in an assignment brief. However, they add that standard research and writing processes should follow.

A more detailed, if also somewhat more problematic assessment was as follows:

I think the keyword there is tool. It's like anything else. Like, if you're looking for information on a topic [...], in theory, the medium is the same as if you go to the library, check out a book, read up on a specific theory or topic and you get the information that way. I would probably use AI as a starting point, d'you know? I usually still do that. To this day, if I want to look at something really, really quickly, really, really general, despite the fact that it's not the most reliable source, I'd check the Wikipedia page first just for a general overview and then take it from there. But I think it would be a very useful tool in that regard, but obviously the temptation when something is spat out with such ease on a particular topic, particularly if it's a written submission work or something like that, then obviously the temptation is greater ... on that. But yeah, I would say a very useful starting tool, but has to remain that: a tool.

Implicit in this student's narrative of GenAI as a ‘starting point’ is a defence of the stance taken on its status as a ‘tool’. Acknowledgement of issues of authenticity and reliability are countered by a narrative of neutral utility and the awareness of the need for some kind of ‘fact-checking’. It is, however, pertinent that the limit at which the ‘tool’ is abandoned and the process of human research resumes is not identified, recalling the difficulty being experienced by learners and educators alike in understanding where the boundary between acceptable and unacceptable use is now located, as reported by Corbin et al. (2025c).

Barrett and Pack (2023), too, found broad consensus between students and teachers on the acceptability of using GenAI to assist in early stages of assessments, particularly where the learner has previously demonstrated competence in the task being outsourced. Similarly, respondents to Johnston et al. (2025) survey largely endorse use of GenAI for the purposes of writing enhancement.

A final area in which our participants expressed worry about avoiding misconduct was perceived issues in relation to guidance from their lecturers and university. Four participants directly stated that they do not know what lecturers are asking for when they ask students to act with AI. This may, to some extent, be a function of uncertainty among academics themselves since, as Eaton (2024) has noted, academic integrity policies seldom address themselves to teaching and research staff. However, that lecturers and the university are sometimes thought to be offering scant or evasive guidance is more likely a result of increasing uncertainty among educators regarding the changing norms of assessment integrity.

Three participants noted limited direction and explicitness from lecturers or from university guidelines. One final-year undergraduate student argued that

the only thing that I've ever seen on that [GenAI] until my 4th year is lecturers saying ‘don't plagiarise, make sure you reference properly.’ That is the only reference that I've had to academic integrity. Yeah, the modules are on Canvas. I think it's popped up, but that's been it and I've been here for four years.

Another claims not be aware of any resources, saying they ‘haven't seen anything come along the tracks’. They go on to add that ‘maybe something has to come’.

Integrity as inherent to being-a-student

As indicated above, some participants invoked values and dispositions intrinsic to the learner-as-person(ality) as determinants of AI rather than externally defined and monitored requirements. These values equated to generally good moral behaviour, with one participant explaining that ‘when I think about integrity in general, I think about values, morals’. There is a not insignificant overlap between our participants’ relatively vague construction of the concept of integrity and the loose definition of *academic* integrity put forth by the International Center for Academic Integrity (2021, p. 4), which envisions a ‘commitment to six fundamental values: honesty, trust, fairness, respect, responsibility, and courage’.

Our participants’ thoughts on the values of AI reflected the incompleteness of the definitions developed to date. Indeed, much as the ICAI definition stops short of comprehensively defining what constitutes academic integrity, so, too, did our students experience some difficulty in situating these value descriptors in a particularly academic context or practice.

Four participants directly link AI with honesty, which, perhaps unsurprisingly, is equated with doing assessments without deception. Two of these four also point to truthfulness with regard to what is submitted. One participant sees ‘being dishonest’ as AM, and another adds that bending of rules ‘brings the whole thing into disrepute’. A further two see dishonesty as an affront to ‘the system’, stating that AM can be characterised as ‘wilfully deceiving the system’ or ‘gaming the system’.

‘Respect for the world of academia’ is seen by one student as essential to AI, although they clarify that students should ‘just act the part [...] because it is a privilege to be in education and you should show respect back to the institution by being honest’. This sentiment is echoed by another student:

I think integrity refers to you as a student and your self-respect and your kind of, like, pride and ego, but in the good sense and not, like, bad pride and ego, but your kind of ... like how you carry yourself in the world of academia and how you present to the world as a student.

Not unlike policymakers, it is at this boundary between theory and practice that our participants struggle to envision how this integrity might be enacted. Amid a sectoral identity crisis, this uncertainty on how the general desire to respect one’s scholarly community and conduct oneself honestly can be achieved represents an estimable threat.

Responsibility was mentioned by two participants, and is of particular interest because, in both cases, this is constructed beyond the individual level and beyond the assessment realm. Instead, both participants highlight the responsibility of the individual student to the academic collective, and to the values and norms of that community as a measure against which the student can test their own personal ‘student integrity’. One highlights ‘that *responsibility as a community*; we have to support each other. And where it’s, like, OK to support others. Not like supporting someone’s assignments and do it for them or not like that’ [emphasis ours], pointing to a developed sense of reciprocal support as a component of integrity in an educational setting.

Responsibility to and in the academic community is also understood as a commitment to *be present* within that community:

Responsibility is kind of the integrity because that means you kind of define yourself in community: are you an integral person [*sic.*] or not? So even if you do some misconduct that will harm your integrity; as an example ... let’s say you cut lectures ... I don’t think it’s an offence, but let’s say if it’s an offence and that doesn’t mean anything about integrity, right? You just don’t show up for the lectures, but it can be considered as a misconduct. But then in the larger context, people may see, like, OK, this person is not attending lectures or not in the community of education ... that kind of has impact on your integrity as a person in the community. So, it’s ... it’s a tough call.

Read in combination, both dispositions are clearly thought to be about mutual support, community, presence, and transparency, reflecting the discourse of ‘belonging’ in the student engagement literature (Ahn and Davis 2019; Ajjawi et al. 2025; Pedler, Willis, and Nieuwoudt 2022; Tinto 2015).

Interestingly, little comment on GenAI permeated the participants' discussion of the broad moral components of AI, although its use by students for social support, to enhance academic success, and/or to enhance engagement retention are now emerging as a subfield of student engagement scholarship (Allen, Pani, and Cowling 2024; Nguyen et al. 2024).

Discussion and conclusion: toward a new academic integrity?

Mejía and Garcés-Flórez (2025, 3) envision *acting with academic integrity* thus:

[S]tanding before others and with others to protect the *integrity of academic practice* and pursue the internal goods and values of excellence related to learning and growth, and to knowledge production and sharing, that define education and research as worthwhile activities whose value we collectively endorse and in whose collective interpretation we actively participate. [Emphasis original]

Renegotiating AI for a fundamentally altered landscape will require sustained attention to displacing the outmoded paradigm of AI as the avoidance of assessment misconduct. Our study reveals at least some awareness among learners that integrity is dispositional rather than occasional, and indicates an important starting point for the remaking of AI for post-GenAI Higher Education. That the episodic understanding of AI which was dominant in our study pertains to a paradigm of knowledge production which is now all but obsolete indicates the urgency of this reframing. In responding to this, however, we will be addressing just one of the two pillars of AI (Mejía and Garcés-Flórez 2025, 12): 'integrity *within* academic practice'.

The applicability of the detection- and sanctions-based understanding of AI which predominate in our participants' constructs will continue to diminish as GenAI grows in sophistication. It is worrisome that students expressed a need for better and clearer direction on 'staying inside' the shifting boundaries between the acceptable and the unacceptable. These were already unstable before GenAI, and thus, it is now crucial that we advance our understanding(s) of how GenAI will remake academic ethics.

The predictable emergence of GenAI as a critical theme in our study is testament to the necessity of keeping it firmly in frame as we redraw the boundaries of the acceptable. However, this renegotiation requires us to think not only about how we assess students, assure standards, validate learning, and award qualifications, but also about which kinds of learning are essential to the satisfaction of these outcomes. For instance, does almost frictionless, arguably struggle-free, 'personalised' learning meet renewed AI standards? Can the integration of GenAI into the lecture theatre do so? As Konstantinidis (2025, 2) has asked, '[w]hat future do we tacitly normalize through the integration of these technologies?' Confrontation of these challenges will represent a response to the second pillar of AI – 'the integrity of academic practice' (Mejía and Garcés-Flórez 2025, 12).

While Corbin, Dawson, and Liu (2025b) have already demonstrated the need for synchronous checkpoints in the assessment process to ensure validity, meaningful renegotiation of AI will require us to look, too, to the processes of learning and teaching: how can these be assured such that the potential utility of GenAI is not overlooked or constrained, but its use also does not threaten the integrity or the value of Higher Education? Here, it is worth re-emphasising the tension between those of our responses that framed GenAI as a necessary component of teaching and learning to ensure adequate workplace preparation and the countervailing view that cognitive over-reliance on it might result in reduced capacity to adapt to the demands of working life.

Perhaps more importantly still, if GenAI is now inherently a component of the debate on AI, more clear-eyed and more extensive debate on the very ethics of the technology and its impact on people and planet is critical to a reimagination of the integrity of academic practice. It is especially urgent in light of emerging discourses of GenAI's utility as a 'tool' or as an aid to a personalised – or, perhaps more accurately, individualised – experience of learning, which are reflected by some of our participants. As Konstantinidis (2025, 3) has argued, this focus on utility risks 'anthropomorphizing the technology, suggesting an agency or empathy it does not possess', but also overlooking the

biases it propagates, the problematic power structures it reinforces, and the ethical compromises it necessitates.

While we are confident that the findings outlined above are compelling, and a necessary addition to the wealth of survey data which already exists, we note a number of limitations of this study which may open the way for additional research. In the first instance, while our data are rich, our sample size was necessarily relatively limited, leaving scope for further qualitative investigation of developing attitudes to academic integrity and misconduct, particularly in light of increasing cognitive offloading to GenAI. We note, too, that our focus group findings necessarily reflect the stances of those learners who volunteered to participate, who are likely to be among the university's more engaged learners.

Additionally, since our focus groups were conducted, the debate around the ethics and integrity implications of GenAI, in particular, has broadened. As we have indicated above, now-prominent issues that did not arise in our focus groups included, for example, material and non-material extractionism; data privacy and (mis)use; (in)equity of access; energy and associated environmental impacts; vested commercial interests; poor labour practices all along the GenAI supply chain; and intensification of biases and discrimination (Coeckelbergh 2022; Crawford 2021; Higher Education Authority 2025; Nguyen et al. 2024; Rudolph, Ismail, and Popenici 2024; UNESCO 2023). More qualitative research with both learners and academics is therefore merited to measure the evolution of awareness of and interest in these core moral-ethical dilemmas.

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